Simon the Cyrene

By Richard Exley

APROACHING THE CITY VIA THE SOUTH Samaria- Jerusalem road, I cannot avoid seeing the place of execution. It is situated on a bare rocky hill in a small triangle, formed where the road converges with the Joppa-Jerusalem road. From a distance it looks remarkably like a bleached skull as it rises fifteen or twenty feet above the surrounding terrain.

Today it is devoid of victims, a fact I note with no little gratitude. Nonetheless, it casts an ominous shadow across the road as I turn toward the Gennath Gate which leads into the city. My sons, Alexander and Rufus, are with me, and they stare in morbid fascination at the three cypress posts which stand like daggers stabbed in the crown of the skull. These are the uprights upon which the cross beams are attached to form the implements of execution. They are permanent, serving as a constant reminder of Roman justice, which is both swift and cruel.

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INTRODUCTION

SIMON WAS A STRANGER IN JERUSALEM, A PILGRIM who had traveled to the holy city to celebrate the Passover with his sons, Alexander and Rufus. He was most likely a devout member of the Jewish Dispersion who had settled in the Greek city of Cyrene in North Africa. Upon entering Jerusalem he was suddenly seized and compelled to carry the cross for a condemned man named Jesus. And through the merciful providence of God his conscription resulted in his conversion. Simon the Cyrene by Richard Exley

Anxious as I am to put that grisly scene behind us, my progress is slowed by the throng of pilgrims who are flooding into the city for the Passover. For us Hebrews it is the holiest of all feasts, commemorating our deliverance from Egypt. Jerusalem, I observe, is alive with anticipation. There are people everywhere. The noise is constant-the cries of street vendors hawking their wares, shouted greetings between old friends, the running laughter of children, the bleating of sheep, and the cooing of doves. For me, the noise is nostalgic, resurrecting long-dead memories of a happier time.

As a boy I journeyed with my parents each year to this very city to celebrate my faith. Then, against their wishes, I married a Greek girl from Cyrene, a cultured city on the northern coast of Africa. Following the wedding, her father invited me to become part of the family's prosperous import business, and I accepted his offer.

Financially it was a good move, but it has not been without its drawbacks. For instance, my children are more Greek than Hebrew. They know almost nothing of their Jewish roots and have never celebrated Passover in the Holy City. Although their mother did not forbid it, she made her wishes clear enough.

In many ways ours is a good marriage, but on the issue of religion we have not been able to agree. She finds my Jewish faith barbaric with its blood sacrifices, not to mention sectarian. I, in turn, cannot stomach the proliferation of gods which her Greek tradition espouses. This year I have risked the peace of our house to celebrate Passover with my sons in the Holy City.

The crowds have stalled and, being a big man, I impatiently shoulder my way through, motioning for the boys to keep up. The side street upon which we are traveling twists around a corner and empties into the Via Dolorosa, where we are

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brought to an abrupt halt. The scene before me turns my stomach, and I frantically attempt to retrace my steps. My sons must not see this. It will spoil the whole Passover experience, taint every memory. Too late I see Rufus and Alexander push through to the front of the crowd. In an instant their ruddy faces turn chalk white. For a moment their eyes are riveted on the drama being played out in the street before them, then they look around wildly, searching the crowd for me. Before I can push through the throng to them, a heavy hand falls upon my shoulder, and I am ordered into the street.

his cannot be happening! I am a respected merchant, a well-placed man in the city of Cyrene. How dare these barbaric Romans cause me to defile myself by participating in the execution of these terrorists! But dare they do and I am powerless to refuse. At the centurion's order I grudgingly shoulder the fallen man's cross and fall in behind him. Shame burns my face and I am thankful the mother of my children is not here to endure this ignominy. Bad enough that my sons should see their father marched through the city in the company of common criminals!

As we move out, I study the men in front of me. At the head of the column is the centurion astride a gray horse. With controlled forcefulness he clears the street of the curious peasants, making way for the condemned men who follow bearing their crosses.

The man whose cross I carry brings up the rear and with each step he lags farther behind. It is not the fear of death that slows his pace, bur the weakness of his abused body. He has been scourged, what the Romans call the "halfway death." It is not supposed to be administered in addition to other punishment, but in his case it has been.

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From time to time, I glance over my shoulder to make sure Rufus and Alexander are part of the crowd which follows our pathetic parade. I would like to send them away in order to spare them this scandalous trauma, but we are strangers in the city and I have no place to send them. It is better, I decide, for them to endure this gruesome experience than for us to risk becoming separated from each other.

Having settled that issue, I turn my attention to the task at hand. We are now ascending the steep hill leading to the Gennath Gate, and I am laboring beneath the weight of the cross. Though I am a large man and well muscled, it has been years since I have done physical labor, leaving me in no condition for this strenuous climb. Before we have reached the half-way point, my garments are soaked with sweat and my lungs are on fire. Ahead of me the beaten man stumbles, and I think he must surely collapse, but somehow he finds the strength to go on. His head is bowed, his breathing labored, his face a suffering mask. Behind me I hear the sound of sobbing. Not a wail but a whimper, and more sorrowful for it. It is coming from a small group of women who seem oblivious to everything except the bleeding man who staggers up the hill toward the place of his death. From the crowd I hear someone say, "It's Mary, his mother. Poor woman."

At last we reach the crown of the skull. Dropping his cross I fall to one knee, fighting to catch my breath. The sun is merciless, and I would give almost anything for a little shade and a drink of cold water. Hardly has that thought taken shape in my mind before a shadow falls across my face, shielding me from the glare. Glancing up, I find myself looking full into his face. My first impulse is to turn away in revulsion, so abused is his visage. One eye is swollen nearly shut, and

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beneath the bruises, his skin is pasty and white. His beard is matted with dried blood, and flecks of spittle coat his raw lips.

Around me things continue as before. The soldiers prepare for the execution. The trailing crowd forms a semicircle before the condemned men. A group of religious leaders stand apart from everyone else, waiting impatiently. The women still weep. But all of this seems to recede, leaving just the two of us alone on this barren hill. Inside my head I hear the ancient words of the prophet Isaiah: "He had no beauty or majesty to attract us to him, nothing in his appearance that we should desire him. He was despised and rejected by men, a man of sorrows, and familiar with suffering. Like one from whom men hide their faces he was despised, and we esteemed him not."2

While I am still puzzling over this passage, he puts his hand upon my shoulder. His touch is both a blessing and a benediction, causing me to tremble-not in revulsion, but in reverence. Before I can speak a soldier shoves me out of the way, while two others grab the man called Jesus and position him on the cross. An order is given, and the heavy hammer falls. It strikes the five-inch spike with a resounding clang that rolls over the crowd like a death knell.

I walk away, never looking back. I have no stomach for this sort of thing. Try as I may though, I am never able to forget this day or more especially the Jewish carpenter who placed his work-hardened hand on my shoulder just before laying it on the cross to receive that Roman nail.

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